# REVOLUTION AND RETREAT

**The youth have driven some of the biggest calls for change India has seen, but these big mass movements have had their limitations too**

By DIPANKAR GUPTA

*Illustration by* NILANJAN DAS

There have been many movements in India where the youth have played a significant role. The uprising against Hindi in the south, the long Assam agitations, the Gujarat-based Navnirman stir, the anti-Mandal protests, the list goes on. Needless to say, if there is an uprising anywhere, the young will be in the mix like turmeric in Indian cuisine. Even so, the anti-corruption movement of 2011 helmed by Anna Hazare was different. For the first time, this mobilisation was truly altruistic and "other" oriented. It was not to get a leg up in the job market, not to let outsiders (however defined) rise above the locals, not to overthrow a government, but to squash what was seen as end-to-end corruption for the larger social good.

One can go sociological and argue that if the youth felt so strongly about corruption, there must be a much deeper reason for it. The cause was perhaps so deep that it stirred the unconscious without the activists being fully aware of its existence. Even a cursory look at those who thronged around Anna Hazare at the Ramlila grounds in August 2011 would show that they were not labourers or indigent farmers, but young aspirants to the country's middle class. It was not absolute poverty that was driving them as much as disillusionment with their life prospects as they moved on to a more mature age. It was relative deprivation rather than an animal theory of revolution that was spurring them on.

For these thwarted youngsters, the prospect of joblessness was perhaps less upsetting than being stuck in a job beneath their station and qualifications. So

